

The Parthenon

Generally viewed as the archetypal Greek temple, the Parthenon (c.432 BCE) was designed by Ictinus, Callicrates and Phidias, and dedicated to the virgin (*parthenos*) goddess Athena, patron of Athens. Though it has some Ionic features, it is mainly Doric, with dimensions in the Doric length–breadth ratio of 9:4. Beneath its painted and gilded roof was a massive gold and ivory sculpture of Athena. While most Greek temples had six columns across the front, the Parthenon had eight. A total of 46 outer supporting columns of marble stood over 10 metres (33 ft) high; they are Doric, with simple capitals and fluted shafts, and the stylobate (column platform) is gently curved to shed rainwater and add strength. To compensate for the optical illusion of dead-straight columns appearing thin-waisted, the architects thickened them – a subtle distortion known as *entasis*. Above the architrave of the entablature was a frieze of 92 metopes (marble panels), while across the lintels of the inner columns runs a continuous frieze in low relief, comprising one of the Ionic elements of the building.

